

Voluntary Report – Voluntary - Public Distribution

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Report Name: Japan Proposes New JAS Standards for Textured Soy Protein Products

Country: Japan

Post: Tokyo

Report Category: Oilseeds and Products, Agricultural Situation

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Report Highlights:

Japan invites public comments on the newly developed Japanese Agricultural Standards (JAS) for textured soy protein products. Textured Soy Protein Products include soy meat (soybean-based alternative meat products with no animal-derived ingredients) and processed soy meat products (soybean-based products that may contain certain animal-based ingredients). Comments are due on December 4, 2021.

General Information

On November 5, 2021, Japan's Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries (MAFF) [proposed new Japanese Agricultural Standards \(JAS\) for Textured Soy Protein Products](#) (available only in Japanese). The proposed standards would apply to food products manufactured from isolated soy protein: soy meat and processed soy meat products.

In the newly developed JAS, MAFF defines “soy meat” as a processed soybean product with a texture similar to meat products, but no animal-based ingredients. MAFF proposes to require that (i) protein content of soy meat products be at least 10 percent, and (ii) soy meat manufacturing utilizes soy protein with an amino acid score¹ of 100 (i.e., entirely derived from soybeans).

The proposed JAS for “processed soy meat products” prohibits the use of (i) animal products, except dairy and egg, or (ii) processed food derived from animal products, with the exception of condiments. This standard has no amino acid score requirement for raw materials. The newly proposed JAS stipulates that the protein content of processed soy meat products must be at least 1 percent.

The appendices for the proposed standards include instructions on how to calculate the amino acid score and protein content.

JAS

The [Act on Japanese Agricultural Standards \(JA2019-0195\)](#) directs MAFF to establish and regulate voluntary JAS standards. Accredited Registered Certifying Bodies inspect products to ensure conformity with JAS. The JAS label is displayed on JAS-certified products to inform consumers that products meet established JAS requirements.

Comment Submission

[Comments should be submitted in Japanese](#) by December 4, 2021 (Japanese standard time) by mail or electronically:

- *Mail comments to* 〒100-8950 1-2-1 Kasumigaseki, Chiyoda-ku, Tokyo
To: Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries, Minister's Secretariat, New Business and Food Industry Department, Food Manufacture Affairs Division, Standards and Conformity Assessment Policy Office, Standards 2nd Team

¹ Amino acid score, in combination with protein digestibility, is the method used to determine if a protein is complete. It determines the completeness of proteins by their unique composition of essential amino acids.

- *Electronic submission:* Go to [e-Gov](#). After agreeing to the conditions, click “意見入力へ” to submit comments.

Isolated Soy Protein and Alternative Meat Market

According to the Japan Plant Protein Food Association, Japan’s annual production of isolated soy proteins reached 44,198 metric tons in 2020. Plant protein already has an established [JAS](#) quality standard (available only in Japanese). Fuji Oil in Osaka Prefecture is Japan’s largest isolated soy protein producer. Fuji Oil supplies isolated soy protein to food manufacturers across Japan. Products produced from soy protein isolates, including soy meat products, have been growing in popularity. Recognizing the recent global success of plant-based meat substitutes, Japan’s large meat-processing companies and hamburger chains have also turned their attention to the development of “alternative meats” ([JA2020-0024](#)) manufactured from soy protein. Since late 2019, large convenience store chains have sold ready-to-eat meals containing “alternative meat” products. For more details about Japanese food-grade soybeans, please see [JA2021-0040](#). For general information about the soybean market in Japan, please consult [Japan Oilseeds Annual](#).

Attachments:

No Attachments.